Examining the Influence of Recruitment Tactics on Desertion Rates During the Vietnam War

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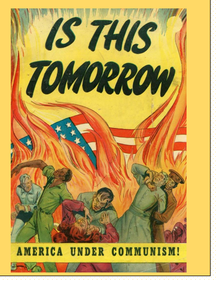
Introduction/Background

Inspired by my father, who was a draft dodger during the war on the Vietnam side, I wanted to research the topic of draft dodgers during the Vietnam War. My focus is on the period of between the start of war (1950) to the end of Vietnam War (1975). During this period, taken place is the Cold War clashed with the ideology of the Democratic government and Communist governments. Shaping everything that was fought in the Vietnam War in the first place led to the United States taking this war so seriously. As such, this event shapes more into my specific topic by giving the facts of what the two countries are fighting for. Leading more to a pathway of the question, did they recruit so many soldiers that many of them didn't even want to go with the global aspect of trying to also find out that reason on the Vietnam side?

The Cold War

"Anywhere there is communism, there is terrorism and assassination". Was what the United States warned the South Vietnamese community in 1954, sparking the beginning in tensions of the Vietnam War. With ideological conflict happening between the United States and the Soviet Union, there was a very strong urge for the United States to make a point in this war. The United States and the Soviet Union regarded the conflict not just as a civil war between North and South Vietnam but as a significant engagement of the Cold War in a strategic region. Due to this, the United States and North Vietnamese Army will start to recruit soldiers for the war very aggressively.



Recruitment Tactics

The Viet Cong recruited effectively by capitalizing on multiple factors including social discontent, offering itself as the hero for the oppressed, especially among those marginalized by the South Vietnamese government. Focusing on young men aged 17-35, particularly those eligible for conscription, they portrayed themselves as a preferable alternative to the South Vietnamese Army. Promising technical training and education, they appealed to ambitious youth seeking personal growth and future opportunities. Additionally, the Viet Cong employed coercion and manipulation, using blackmail and narratives from deserters to paint the South Vietnamese Army as undesirable, thereby strengthening local support networks and securing essential resources from villages.

On the other side, The American draft system during the Vietnam War was marked by significant inequalities, with socioeconomic background, race, and education level heavily influencing who was more likely to be drafted and serve in combat. Marginalized groups, including Black and Hispanic individuals, faced higher exposure to combat risks, while college graduates had a lower likelihood of deployment. Widespread opposition led to substantial draft evasion and resistance, with many young men seeking exemptions or fleeing to avoid service. This growing discontent ultimately prompted President Nixon to end draft calls in 1972, transitioning the U.S. military to an all-volunteer force the following year.

Desertion Rate

Viet Cong soldiers as well as Vietnamese citizens, not only deserted just the war, but they also defected. Defections among Viet Cong soldiers were driven largely by practical hardships like food shortages, poor medical care, and prolonged family separation, which led many to abandon the struggle. Additionally, the devastating effects of U.S. airpower and artillery eroded morale, while some soldiers, especially those without strong ideological commitment, became disillusioned with the prolonged war and its mounting sacrifices.

Between July 1966 and December 1973, over 503,000 U.S. military personnel deserted during the Vietnam War. This serves as a reflection of the widespread discontent that Americans felt about the war. The key factors to this desertion rate stem from not being able to justify the government's motivation for fighting so hard in this war. Additionally, there was an anti-Vietnam War movement and influence, which challenged many citizens' and soldier's views on the conflict. Coupled with the unfairness of the drafting system, many Americans decided to either protest against the war or desert the country altogether.

Conclusion

While ideology appeals initially served as powerful recruitment tools, the brutal realities of the Vietnam War, the hardships of combat, and the psychological toll of prolonged conflict eventually undermined these narratives. The gap between the idealized portrayal of the war and the lived experiences of soldiers on both sides contributed to widespread disillusionment, declining morale, and a significant desertion rate. This complex interplay underscores the limitations of ideology in sustaining prolonged conflicts and highlights the human cost of war.

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